Ahmedabad. Modi's response, he recalls, was: 'How quickly can we do this?'

Among global politicians, only then US president Barack Obama and then Australian prime minister Julia Gillard had been on Hangouts thus far. The platform was looking for celebrities to engage with in India. Bollywood stars Shah Rukh Khan and Aamir Khan, as well as cricketer Mahendra Singh Dhoni, were among the celebrities who had featured on Google Hangouts. Modi became the first politician to join this list.[4]

At the time of the Devgn Hangout in 2012, Modi had 8 million followers on Twitter (rising to 61.5 million by September 2020), 6 million on Facebook (growing to 45.8 million by 2020).[5] He was already way ahead of all other Indian politicians (barring Shashi Tharoor at the time) on social media.[6] Rahul Gandhi, for example, did not even join Twitter until March 2015, and started tweeting under his own name only from March 2018.[7] Modi, however, was willing to go the whole hog with a social platform, using it to directly reach his voters, bypassing what he may have seen as the distorting lens of the media. To a question on the chat from a self-confessed fan on how he managed to stay calm despite media criticism, Modi said he welcomed criticism as such, but argued that what he faced in the country was not criticism but allegations by vested interests.

Modi's dominance of the digital world first became a national talking point in 2014, when he used social media and his hologram rallies to great effect. Yet, his embrace of technology as a force multiplier in politics predates this general election. Modi first deployed 3D holograms of himself not in 2014, but in the 2012 Gujarat assembly elections. Soon after that, in March 2013, while addressing the Google Big Tent summit, again via Google Hangouts, he argued: '"Technology in Politics" plays a crucial role … The internet has therefore truly empowered the citizen. It has forced the politician to perform, not just promise. In a way, it has become a challenge for the political class. The time has come for the political class to adapt to this change and reinvent itself! It needs to stop running away. It needs to embrace the internet's many powerful facets … In this age of internet democracy, citizens are netizens, who transcend the geographical borders of countries and continents.